



Changing streams: Indian table tennis player Archana Kamath, who was part of the women's team that made a historic quarterfinal run at the Paris Olympics earlier this month, has decided to retire from professional play to focus on her higher studies. AFP

know what the players need and what we try to provide.

The work we put in in the past few months has been absolutely positive. We work in good cooperation; I have given my contributions, and they have given theirs. It was fine. I haven't seen any disturbance at the national camps, and the players were absolutely comfortable.

You are considered a lucky mascot. All the players adore you. What is it about you and this Indian team?

(Laughs) I don't know. I trust the players, and maybe that's why they feel like that. I never had the feeling that 'this player cannot make it' or 'this one is difficult'. One of the first things I tell my players is, 'I trust you'.

They feel the support. They need someone to back their talent.

Sometimes we get stuck, thinking maybe some player is attacking on my forehand or someone else's serve is good. Well, what about your skills? Why do we place so much importance on what our opponents are doing well? We are here to just change the perspective.

Then, to what extent does one need to analyse the opponent before a tie?

Every player has some sort of fixed pattern. It is important for coaches to identify these skills quickly. Ultimately, it is the player who controls the rally when they serve and receive. It is a flow, and there is not much time for players to think and do what the coach says. My job is to give them a little bit of warning as to what the opposition may do in certain match situations, as players tend to play in recurring patterns.

You have trained so many teams since 1995, like the UAE and the USA. What has been your core

guiding philosophy?

My core philosophy has changed over the years. Earlier, I used to think I was the key person. Now, I say that the player is the key person. Many coaches have this attitude of being the ones who make things happen. Yes, it is true.

But again, players are the performers. I try to develop myself to identify more potential in the players. I don't talk too tactically, but I try to find in every player an additional way to win points. The rest comes with discussion and implementation. It is a process.

Finally, how do you see Archana Kamath's retirement from the sport to take up academics?

She was always good at academics. The news hasn't surprised me much. At 24 itself, she has had a lot of experience. During her time in the US, she can choose to continue playing. If she wants to join some training with the national team again, she is always welcome. I am sure it is not a goodbye. I hope to see her again.